

women went out to work, challenging conventional ideas of women as housewives and homemakers. Above all, the emergence of the contraceptive pill (see left) liberated women, offering them a reliable method of birth control for the first time.



The New Wave
A Bout de Souffle (Breathless), 1960, directed by Jean-Luc Godard, is one of the best-known films of French New Wave cinema.

the optimism of the decade soon started to unravel, influenced by the assassinations in the US of Senator Robert

Kennedy and Martin Luther King Jr. (see pp.432–33) in 1968. Around the world, students protested at the increased involvement of US troops in the Vietnam War (see pp.430–31). The US saw race riots in the inner cities, and the civil rights movement shifted from a nonviolent position when elements of it were taken over by radical extremists.

In France, the student revolt of May 1968 in Paris linked up with a general strike of 10 million workers, who called for the overthrow of Charles de Gaulle's government.

The end of the decade was marked by two important rock festivals held in

1969—Woodstock in New York and the Altamont Free Concert in California. At Woodstock, 450,000 people attended the three-day festival, gathering in the spirit of love and sharing, but at Altamont, a black fan was stabbed to death by a gang of white Hells Angels.

“The thing **the sixties** did was to show us the possibilities and the responsibility that we all had. It wasn't the answer. It just **gave us a glimpse of the possibility.**”

JOHN LENNON, LAST RADIO INTERVIEW, DECEMBER 8, 1980

The 1970s saw an abrupt end to the idealism that characterized the 1960s.

1970s

In 1973 the world experienced an oil crisis **440–41** >>, which affected the economies of developed nations. In Britain there was a **downturn in economic fortunes** and unemployment was on the increase.

PUNK

The commercialism of pop music was soon challenged in the 1970s by Punk music. An **antiestablishment** and **rebellious** movement, it was epitomized by bands such as the Ramones in the US and the Sex Pistols in the UK.



SEX PISTOLS

GLOBAL POP

In the 1980s MTV was launched, and pop artists became global stars. In 1985 the Live Aid concert was watched by **1.5 billion viewers** across 100 countries.

